

RACHELE BENJAMIN, PHD

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ABOUT

User Experience Researcher with 10+ years of academic and industry research experience. Spirited storyteller, big-picture thinker.

SKILLS

Qualitative methods | interviews, diary studies, field studies, ethnography, concept value testing, prototype testing, Jobs to be Done, user journey mapping, persona building, moderated and unmoderated usability tests

Quantitative methods | surveys, logs analysis, segmentation, multivariate analysis, A/B testing

Advanced statistical modeling for behavioral research | cluster analysis, multilevel and path modeling, factor analysis (exploratory, confirmatory), regression, ANOVA, *t*-tests

Design Strategy | aligning business objectives with human-centered design principles, analyzing the competitive environment, hosting ideation sessions with stakeholders

Design Thinking | delivering workshops and co-creation sessions, coaching teams to become design thinking experts

Proficiencies | Qualtrics, UserTesting, Dscout, Figjam, Miro, R, SPSS, Figma

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Social and Personality Psychology (Quantitative Methods Minor) | The University of British Columbia
September 2017 – March 2022

M.A. in Social and Personality Psychology | The University of British Columbia
September 2015 – April 2017

BA (Honors) in Psychology | Queen's University
September 2010 – April 2015

EXPERIENCE

Usability Researcher 3 | Microsoft, Full-Time (Contract)

August 2024 - present

- Served as the sole Researcher for the Enterprise version of Microsoft Edge, supporting over 10 million users worldwide. Designed, scoped, and led generative product research that uncovered actionable insights to inform the vision and strategy ahead of launching our AI-first browser.
- Led a large-scale Opportunity Analysis for the Shopping product and business teams, uncovering key areas to enhance and automate frequent online shopping tasks using Gen AI. Insights from this generative research drove ideation and concept development.
- Collaborated with the Productivity team, a cross-functional group of product managers, designers, and stakeholders, to develop a tab management tool. Led a research roadmap that began with generative studies uncovering core

efficiency and productivity needs, and continued with evaluative studies revealing how users navigate multiple open tabs. Insights directly shaped product strategy and informed the roadmap for the following year.

- Led rapid evaluative research for the Copilot team to de-risk high-priority concepts shaping the future of AI in the browser. Delivered actionable insights that empowered stakeholders to refine offerings in a fast-moving, highly competitive landscape.

Senior Design Researcher | TD Bank

August 2022 – July 2024

- Worked with a cross-functional team of data analysts, data scientists, and product owners to plan and execute a large-scale intervention study to improve the estate settlement journey. Acted as the research SME to ensure that the intervention produced valuable and actionable insights.
- Led end-to-end research on safe investing vehicles (e.g., GICs, ETFs) starting with 1:1 interviews and culminating in co-design with users and top banking executives. Developed useful, usable, and delightful digital products that resonated with users during volatile market conditions.
- Secured funding for generative research, helping bank leaders prepare for a future with Open Banking. Executed a multi-phased research program uncovering user needs, concerns, and adoption factors of open data sharing.

Data Analytics, Claims | Co-operators

May 2022 – August 2022

- Programmed an interactive dashboard in R Markdown that connected business stakeholders with live data, ensuring clarity and delivering information tailored to improve decision-making and meet their reporting needs.

Doctoral Researcher | UBC Psychology Department

September 2015 – March 2022

- Led various quantitative surveys exploring the relationships between the self, technology, and society, from AI and the uncanny valley, to existential threats like pandemics and wars, to democratic downturns. Published my research in high-impact journals: <https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Rachele-Benjamin>
- Analyzed large cross-national datasets to identify personality and contextual predictors of people's commitment to democratic principles, applying complex statistical models.
- Flexibly and creatively applied different experimental and survey methods to uncover discrepancies between people's behaviors and intentions to uphold democracy's principles.
- Mentored undergraduate students and guided them through the process of study design, recruitment, implementation, and analysis.
- Co-facilitated a working group on best practices in online teaching.

Adjunct Professor | Capilano University

June 2021 – August 2021

- Designed and delivered a flexible and accessible remote online course introducing students to Psychology Principles.